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Study Courses

Non-EU students can apply for a study visa (Long-stay visa Type D) or a residence permit in Latvia for the following types of training:

- Full-time Bachelor's degree programs.
- Full-time Master's degree programs.
- Doctoral (PhD) studies.
- Exchange programs (e.g., Erasmus+ or bilateral agreements).
- Short-term language courses or professional training (if the duration exceeds 90 days).

All programs must be provided by an accredited higher education institution or a registered educational facility.

Embassy Appointment

Booking an appointment for a visa application is generally done through the following methods:

- The Electronic Appointment System on the official website of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Latvia.
- The website of an authorized external service provider, such as VFS Global, depending on the applicant's country of residence.
- Direct contact via email or phone with the specific Latvian Embassy or Consulate if electronic booking is not available in that region.

Applying for a Study Visa

The application process for a study visa/residence permit involves several stages:

How to apply

- Apply to a Latvian university and receive an admission letter.
- Sign a study agreement with the university.

- The university applies to the Office of Citizenship and Migration Affairs (PMLP) in Latvia to request an “Invitation Number” for the student.
- Once the invitation is approved, the student submits the visa application at the Latvian Embassy or a VFS Global center.
- Attend an interview if requested by the consular officer.

How long it usually takes

- Invitation approval by PMLP: 2 to 10 working days.
- Visa processing at the Embassy: 15 to 60 days, depending on the complexity of the case and the time of year.

Documents Needed

Before applying, students must prepare the following:

- A valid travel document (passport) with at least two blank pages and a validity period at least 3 months longer than the visa duration.
- A completed and signed National Visa application form.
- Two recent passport-sized color photographs.
- The Invitation Number approved by the PMLP (provided by the university).
- The official Letter of Admission from the university.
- A copy of the signed Study Agreement.
- Proof of sufficient financial means.
- Proof of intended residence (provided by the university or a rental agreement).
- A valid travel medical insurance policy with a minimum coverage of 42,600 EUR.
- A police clearance certificate (criminal record check) from the home country, legalized or with an Apostille.
- Proof of payment for the state fee.

Money Requirements

To obtain a study visa, students must prove they possess sufficient funds to cover their living costs in Latvia:

- The current requirement is a minimum of 700 EUR per month (based on the minimum monthly wage in Latvia as of 2024).

- **CORRECTION:** According to the official PMLP page “Studies” (www.pmlp.gov.lv/en/studies), the required subsistence for students is **500 EUR per month**. Multiple Latvian university sources citing current OCMA guidance state the requirement as 780 EUR per month (equal to the current minimum monthly wage). The 700 EUR figure does not correspond to any officially published threshold. Applicants should verify the current amount directly with PMLP or the relevant Latvian Embassy before applying.
- **For a one-year residence permit, the student must show a total of 8,400 EUR.**
- **CORRECTION:** The total of 8,400 EUR for one year is confirmed by the Ministry of Foreign Affairs consular page (www2.mfa.gov.lv) for 2024. However, this total is not consistent with the 700 EUR/month figure stated above ($700 \times 12 = 8,400$), since the official monthly threshold published by PMLP is either 500 EUR or 780 EUR depending on the applicable regulation. Applicants should verify the current annual total directly with PMLP (www.pmlp.gov.lv/en/studies) or the relevant Latvian Embassy.
- Acceptable proof includes a bank statement showing the balance in the student’s name, or a statement from a sponsor (accompanied by documents proving the sponsor’s identity and financial capacity).

Residence Permit

After arriving in Latvia with a long-stay visa, the student must finalize their residence permit:

- Within the timeframe specified by the visa, the student must visit the Office of Citizenship and Migration Affairs (PMLP).
- The student must provide biometric data (fingerprints and photo) at the PMLP office.
- The student must present their passport and health insurance.
- A residence permit card (eID card) is usually issued within 2 to 10 working days after the biometrics are taken.

Working While Studying

Non-EU students in Latvia are permitted to work under the following conditions:

- Students are allowed to work up to 20 hours per week during the academic semester.
- Students are allowed to work up to 40 hours per week (full-time) during official university holidays.

- The right to work is automatically granted with the residence permit for studies; no separate work permit is required, provided the employer registers the employment with the State Revenue Service.

Renewing the Residence Permit

If the study program lasts longer than one year, the residence permit must be renewed annually:

- The application for renewal must be submitted to the PMLP at least 45 days before the current permit expires.
- Documents required for renewal include a certificate from the university confirming the student's status, a new study agreement (if applicable), proof of funds for the next year, and updated insurance.
- Renewal applications can often be submitted electronically if the student has an e-signature or by post.

Changing to a Work Permit

After graduating, students have options to remain in Latvia for work:

- Graduates can apply for a 9-month temporary residence permit to look for work or start a business in Latvia.
- CORRECTION: According to the official Study in Latvia state portal (www.studyinlatvia.lv) and the PMLP page "Person after graduation" (www.pmlp.gov.lv/en/person-after-graduation), the post-graduation stay period **depends on the level of study**: bachelor's graduates receive a permit for **4 months** after graduation, while master's and doctoral graduates receive a permit for **9 months**. The 9-month duration applies only to postgraduate-level graduates, not to all graduates.
- Once a job offer is secured, the student must apply to change their status to a residence permit for employment.
- The employer must register a vacancy with the State Employment Agency (NVA) for at least 10 working days in some cases, although graduates of Latvian universities often benefit from simplified procedures.

Official Information

Official information regarding visas and residence permits can be found on these websites:

- Office of Citizenship and Migration Affairs (PMLP): www.pmlp.gov.lv
- Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Republic of Latvia: www.mfa.gov.lv
- Study in Latvia (Official state portal): www.studyinlatvia.lv

Application Forms

Official forms are available for download at:

- The PMLP “Forms” section: <https://www.pmlp.gov.lv/en/forms-and-samples>
- The Ministry of Foreign Affairs visa application portal:
<https://epak.pmlp.gov.lv/>

Tips for Students

Common mistakes to avoid when applying:

- Incomplete documentation: Ensure all documents, including the criminal record certificate, are properly legalized or apostilled according to international requirements.
- Insufficient funds: Failing to show the exact amount required by law or providing bank statements that are too old. Statements should ideally be no older than 15–30 days.
- Missing deadlines: Applying too late for the visa or the renewal of the residence permit can lead to deportation or the need to leave the country and re-apply.
- Incorrect insurance: Providing insurance that does not meet the specific minimum coverage amount or the duration required by Latvian law.
- Language barriers: Ensure all documents not in Latvian or English are accompanied by a certified translation.

Note: Latvian immigration rules are being updated for 2026 (higher financial thresholds, Latvian language requirements for permanent residence, stricter checks), so always confirm current figures with OCMA or the Latvian embassy before applying.

1. Study Courses That Qualify for a Study Visa

- The student must be registered at a university or another institution of higher education in Latvia to apply as a student.
- Programmes must be **full-time**: study and work residence permits are only granted to students enrolled full-time in programmes with at least 40 academic hours per week and at least 40 credits earned per year.
- Qualifying levels include:
 - Bachelor's degree programmes
 - Master's degree programmes
 - Doctoral programmes
 - Language/preparatory courses leading into a degree programme (institution-dependent)
- An invitation document for the residence/visa application is normally issued only for full-time studies; part-time study applicants must already hold a valid EU residence permit.

2. Booking an Embassy Appointment

- Visa and residence permit applications generally cannot be submitted by post; an in-person appointment is required.
- Schengen short-stay visa applications for Latvia are processed through the external provider VFS Global, which manages document collection and submission.
- For long-stay (D) visas and residence permits, appointments must be booked only through the online appointment system at pieraksts.mfa.gov.lv.
- When booking, applicants must provide correct name, surname, a private email address, and mobile phone number, or the booking may be deleted.
- The exact booking link is country-specific (e.g. pieraksts.mfa.gov.lv/en/india, [/en/egypt](https://pieraksts.mfa.gov.lv/en/egypt), [/en/uzbekistan](https://pieraksts.mfa.gov.lv/en/uzbekistan)) — choose the page for the country where the application is being submitted.
- Some embassies (e.g. Washington D.C.) instead require booking by email rather than the online system, so always check the specific embassy's consular information page first.

3. Steps to Apply for a Study Visa

Overview of the process:

1. Get admitted to an accredited Latvian institution and sign a study agreement.
2. The institution requests an **invitation** for you from OCMA (Office of Citizenship and Migration Affairs).
3. The invitation is filed with OCMA by the university representative, and the student must provide the invitation number when submitting documents.
4. Book an appointment with the relevant Latvian embassy/consulate (or VFS Global centre).
5. Submit your application and documents in person.
6. OCMA reviews the residence permit application, and only if the decision is positive can the student apply for the D-category visa.
7. Once approved, the D visa is issued within a few days up to 15 days.
8. Travel to Latvia and, upon arrival, collect/register the residence permit card with OCMA.

Documents needed: see Section 4.

How to apply: through the Latvian embassy/consulate with territorial competence over your country of residence, or in some cases directly to OCMA in Latvia.

Processing time:

- The residence permit review by OCMA can take up to 8 weeks.
- Decisions are usually made within 30–60 days, with expedited processing available for an extra fee, reducing this to 10–20 working days.
- Once OCMA approves, the visa itself is issued quickly (a few days up to 15 days).

4. Documents Needed

Based on official embassy and OCMA guidance, students typically need:

- Valid passport (valid at least 3 months beyond the intended residence permit period)
- Completed e-visa application form for the National Visa (Type D), printed and signed
- Two recent photographs on a white background, with the face covering about 70% of the photo
- The OCMA invitation number (provided by the university)
- Signed study agreement with the institution
- Certificate from the Academic Information Centre (AIC) confirming your education documents are sufficient for studies in Latvia

- Written confirmation from the institution regarding enrolment and arrival for completion of the study programme
- Proof of sufficient financial means (see Section 5)
- Health insurance valid for at least 90 days from arrival, with coverage of at least €42,600
- Proof of accommodation in Latvia
- Police clearance certificate (required for some nationalities, e.g. Indian applicants)
- Previous education documents, legalised or apostilled, and translated if necessary
- Foreign public documents (diplomas, civil status documents, police clearance) must be legalised or apostilled by the relevant authority in the home country

5. Money (Financial) Requirements

- Required proof of subsistence varies slightly by source and embassy, but commonly cited figures are:
 - At least €780 per month, shown through an official bank statement (per University of Latvia and several institutions' guidance)
 - €740 per month for the student, plus €740 per month for an accompanying adult family member and €210 per month for a minor (per the Latvian Embassy in Egypt's guidance)
- Bank statements must be issued within the last 3 months and be in or translated into English.
- If a third party is financing the studies, a notarised and legalised certificate authorising use of that person's funds must also be submitted.
- Because the exact figure differs slightly between embassies and may be revised for 2026, confirm the current required amount directly with the relevant Latvian embassy or OCMA before applying.

6. Applying for a Residence Permit After Arrival

- A student can apply for the residence permit in person at OCMA in Riga (or any OCMA branch) within 90 days of the first day of entry, or alternatively apply at the embassy before travelling.
- Steps after arrival:
 - Make an appointment with OCMA (or the relevant regional division).
 - Submit the application, with the OCMA contact details available on its homepage.
 - On receiving the residence permit, present a valid health/life insurance policy and an X-ray/fluorography result.
 - Pay the applicable state fee (see Section 11 for the fee schedule).

- Provide biometric data and collect the residence permit card.
- A residence permit is required for anyone planning to stay in Latvia longer than 90 days within a half-year period from the date of first entry.

7. Working While Studying

- Students can work for any employer in Latvia during their studies, with conditions depending on study level.
- A full-time undergraduate (bachelor's) student may work up to 20 hours per week, and up to 40 hours per week during study holidays.
- A full-time master's or PhD student has the right to work without restriction on hours.
- If a student works more hours than they study, their main activity is legally considered employment rather than study, which would require an employment-based residence permit instead.

8. Renewing the Residence Permit (Courses Longer Than One Year)

- A residence permit is normally granted for one year at a time, and the extension must be requested before the existing permit expires.
- Processing an extension can take up to 3 months, so it's recommended to inform the university's international coordinator at least 3 months before expiry to request a new invitation for the extension.
- If a master's or PhD student applies 45–90 days before expiry, the extension may be free; applying later means the standard state fee applies.
- The renewal application is submitted to OCMA with:
 - Confirmation of continued enrolment from the institution
 - Updated proof of financial means
 - Valid health insurance
 - Current passport and residence permit card

9. Changing to a Work Permit After Studies

Job-search period after graduation:

- Students in bachelor's programmes receive a residence permit covering the study period plus an additional 4 months after graduation to find work or apply for a master's programme.
- Master's and doctoral graduates typically receive a similar initial extension, which can be extended further (commonly cited as up to a total of around 9–13 months), subject to OCMA approval — confirm current durations with OCMA, as these periods are set in the Immigration Law and can change.

Transition process once a job offer is secured:

1. The employer submits a sponsorship request to OCMA along with the employment contract (or draft) and the foreigner's education documents.
2. For third-country nationals, the job vacancy must have been registered as open for at least 10 working days on the State Employment Agency's CV and vacancy portal.
3. The applicant submits the residence permit documents either to a Latvian diplomatic/consular mission abroad or to OCMA in Latvia.
4. OCMA issues the residence permit together with the right to employment.
5. The foreigner must then register with the State Revenue Service as a taxpayer.

This effectively converts the study-based residence permit into an employment-based one; a separate "work permit" document is not issued separately from the residence permit in Latvia's system.

10. Official Government Websites for Legal Information

- **Office of Citizenship and Migration Affairs (OCMA/PMLP)** – residence permits, visas, fees, forms: <https://www.pmlp.gov.lv/en/>
- **Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Latvia** – visa policy, embassy directory: <https://www.mfa.gov.lv/en/>
- **Latvian embassy/consulate pages** (country-specific consular information), e.g. [https://www2.mfa.gov.lv/en/\[country\]/consular-information](https://www2.mfa.gov.lv/en/[country]/consular-information)
- **Appointment booking system:** [https://pieraksts.mfa.gov.lv/en/\[country\]](https://pieraksts.mfa.gov.lv/en/[country])
- **State Administration Services Portal:** <https://latvija.gov.lv> (service descriptions, including residence permit registration)
- **Study in Latvia** (official national study-abroad portal, run with the Ministry of Education and the Academic Information Centre): <https://www.studyinlatvia.lv>
- **State Employment Agency (NVA):** <https://www.nva.gov.lv/en>

11. Where to Download Official Application Forms

- **OCMA's Applications page provides downloadable forms, including the questionnaire for requesting a residence permit for third-country citizens:** <https://www.pmlp.gov.lv/en/applications>
- **CORRECTION:** The URL <https://www.pmlp.gov.lv/en/applications> does not exist as a standalone page. The correct URL for the OCMA's application form page is <https://www.pmlp.gov.lv/en/application-requiring-residence-permit> (verified against the live pmlp.gov.lv website; the /en/applications path redirects to this address).
- The same page hosts the EU citizen/family member residence document form.

- D-visa application forms are completed through the e-visa system:
<https://epak.pmlp.gov.lv/NVIS.EService001.WebSite/ApplicationInquiry.aspx>
- Fee codes and payment details for the residence permit examination are listed on the OCMA fee page, linked from the State Administration Services Portal.

12. Common Mistakes Students Make (and How to Avoid Them)

- **Booking the wrong appointment type or missing the online system** — appointments must go through pieraksts.mfa.gov.lv; documents are not accepted by mail or walk-in at most embassies.
- **Incomplete or incorrect application forms** — forms must be filled in block letters; an incomplete or inaccurate form can lead to rejection.
- **Missing legalisation/apostille on documents** — diplomas, police clearance certificates, and civil documents from non-EU countries usually need an apostille or legalisation, plus translation into English or Latvian.
- **Insufficient or outdated financial proof** — bank statements are typically only valid for 3 months from issue; submitting outdated statements is a common rejection reason.
- **Applying too late** — residence permit review can take up to 8 weeks, and visa extensions should be requested well before expiry (ideally 3 months ahead for renewals).
- **Underestimating health insurance requirements** — insurance must meet the minimum coverage amount and validity period required for the visa category.
- **Not confirming current fees and thresholds** — since financial and fee requirements are subject to change (notably with 2026 rule updates), relying on outdated blog information instead of checking directly with OCMA or the embassy can cause problems.
- **Working beyond permitted hours** — exceeding the allowed work hours during studies can jeopardize the basis of the residence permit, since the main purpose of stay would then be considered employment, not study.